

also be overwhelming as a beginner and difficult to troubleshoot when you aren't sure why your code isn't working in the IDE.

These days, the lines have blurred between text editors and IDEs. Most popular editors have some features that used to be exclusive to IDEs. Likewise, most IDEs can be configured to run in a lighter mode that's less distracting as you work, but lets you use the more advanced features when you need them.

If you already have an editor or IDE installed that you like, and if it's already configured to work with a recent version of Python that's installed on your system, then I encourage you to stick with what you already know. Exploring different editors can be fun, but it's also a way to avoid the work of learning a new language.

If you don't already have an editor or IDE installed, I recommend VS Code for a number of reasons:

- It's free, and it's released under an open source license.
- It can be installed on all major operating systems.
- It's beginner-friendly but also powerful enough that many professional programmers use it as their main editor.
- It finds the versions of Python you have installed, and it typically does not require any configuration to run your first programs.
- It has an integrated terminal, so your output appears in the same window as your code.
- A Python extension is available that makes the editor highly efficient for writing and maintaining Python code.
- It's highly customizable, so you can tune it to match the way you work with code.

In this appendix, you'll learn how to start configuring VS Code so that it works well for you. You'll also learn some shortcuts that let you work more efficiently. Being a fast typist is not as important as many people think in programming, but understanding your editor and knowing how to use it efficiently is quite helpful.

With all that said, VS Code doesn't work for everyone. If it doesn't work well on your system for some reason, or if it's distracting you as you work, there are a number of other editors that you might find more appealing. This appendix includes a brief description of some of the other editors and IDEs you should consider.

Working Efficiently with VS Code

In Chapter 1, you installed VS Code and added the Python extension as well. This section will show you some further configurations you can make, plus shortcuts for working efficiently with your code.

Configuring VS Code

There are a few ways to change the default configuration settings for VS Code. Some changes can be made through the interface, and some will require